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Table 1 Group Composition, Protocol, and Estimate of Developing Cancer in One's Lifetime

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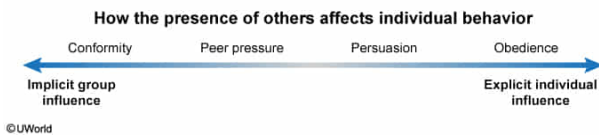
This study appears to have been actually assessing which of the following?

- ✓ ☒ A. Conformity [84%]
☐ B. Peer pressure [9%]
☐ C. Compliance [5%]
☐ D. Obedience

Correct

85% answered correctly

Explanation:



The presence of others impacts individual behavior in a variety of ways.

Conformity occurs when an individual's thoughts or actions **align** with **group norms** (thoughts/behaviors of others) due to the **implicit influence** of others. In other words, there is no explicit request or command, yet an individual still goes along with the group.

Individual characteristics correlated with increased conformity are age (youth), gender (female), and certain personality traits (eg, agreeableness). Group characteristics correlated with increased conformity are size (4–7 members), high levels of group commitment, conditions where consensus is required (eg, jury verdict), situations where the majority approaches unanimity (everyone or almost everyone appears to be in agreement), and increased group power. Social characteristics correlated with increased conformity are collectivism (group valued over the individual) and the threat of punishment for deviance.

This study appears to have been assessing the extent to which individuals in Groups 3 and 4 conformed to a low estimate compared to Groups 1 and 2.

(Choice B) Peer pressure is defined as the influence peers exert on other peers to conform to group norms. Peer groups are composed of individuals who are close in age and share certain traits (eg, attend the same school). Although similar to conformity, peer pressure involves a greater risk of rejection if one fails to conform. In this study, there is no evidence that group members were peers.

(Choice C) Compliance is a type of conformity whereby an individual publicly goes along with the group but privately maintains his or her own stance. Without information regarding the private stance of the subjects, it is not possible to determine if compliance is occurring.

(Choice D) Obedience occurs when individuals behave according to the requests or demands of an authority figure. As there was no authority figure present in this study, obedience was not being assessed.

Educational objective:

Conformity occurs when the implicit influence of a group causes an individual to align his or her thoughts or actions with the group. Increased conformity is correlated with individual (eg, age, gender), group (eg, size, power), and social (eg,

collectivism) characteristics.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400564

System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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Normative social influence is most likely to arise in the group:

- ☐ A. containing several members who have expertise regarding

cancer. [30%]

- ✔ ☒ B. composed of all females from the same university. [42%]
- ☐ C. with an assigned group spokesperson. [18%]
- ☐ D. whose members are the most disparate in socioeconomic status. [8%]

Correct

42% answered correctly

Explanation:

Social influence & conformity		
Social influence	Reasons for conformity	When most likely to occur
Normative	Individual conforms in order to: • fit in, gain approval • avoid disapproval/rejection	Individual identifies with group members, wants to be accepted by the group
Informational	Individual conforms due to: • uncertainty of what to do • believing others know what to do	Individual views other group members as experts

Social influence occurs when other people have an impact on an individual's thoughts or actions. Social influence is a broad topic in sociology that includes concepts such as conformity, obedience, peer pressure, and persuasion. There are two types of social influence that contribute to conformity: Normative and informational.

Normative social influence describes when an individual conforms to **fit in** or **avoid rejection** by others. For example, a college freshman notices that everyone on campus wears yellow wristbands, so he wears one to fit in. Normative social influence would most likely arise in a group composed of females from the same university because individuals tend to want to fit in

with group members with whom they identify.

(Choice A) Informational social influence describes when people conform to what others are doing because they **don't know what to do** and believe others do. If several group members have medical expertise regarding cancer, another participant of that group may conform because the individual believes the others are experts with the best information about cancer risk.

(Choice C) Without further information regarding the group spokesperson, it is not possible to determine if that individual would foster normative social influence within the group.

(Choice D) A disparity in socioeconomic status among the participants is less likely to foster normative social influence because the group members are less likely to identify with each other.

Educational objective:

Social influence describes many group processes (eg, conformity, obedience, peer pressure) and occurs when others affect one's thoughts/behaviors. Normative social influence takes place when people attempt to fit in, and informational social influence occurs when people assume others have more information and know what to do.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400565
System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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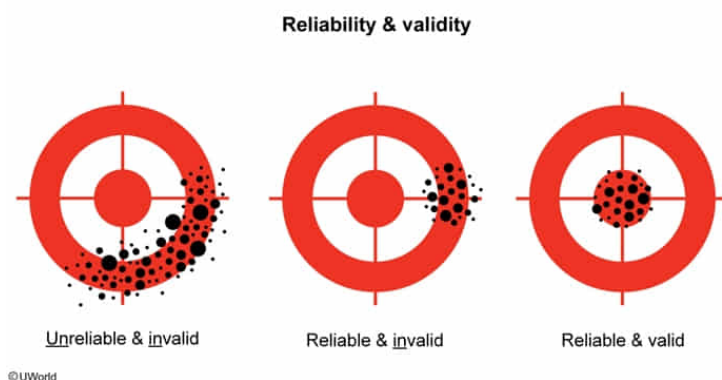
If this study is repeated using the same procedure with a different set of subjects and produces similar results, this suggests that the study is:

- ✓ ☒ A. reliable. [77%]
☐ B. valid. [9%]
☐ C. generalizable. [13%]
☐ D. neutral.

Correct

77% answered correctly

Explanation:



A variety of criteria are used to judge the extent to which scientific findings are credible (ie, can be trusted or believed). Major criteria include reliability, validity, and neutrality.

Reliability refers to the **consistency** of an experiment or measure. Reliable measures produce similar results every time. For example, two official MCATs taken by the same person on consecutive days should produce similar scores. If the scores differ dramatically, this would be considered an unreliable test.

Similarly, if a study is well designed, it should produce similar results when repeated with new subjects. This is an indication that an experimental design is highly reliable, also referred to as **replicability**, or reproducibility.

(Choice B) Validity can be internal or external. Internal validity refers to the extent to which an experiment or measure is accurate (ie, produces a true result). For example, a broken scale might consistently show your weight as 10 pounds lighter, which would be consistent (reliable) but not accurate (valid).

(Choice C) External validity, also known as generalizability, is the extent to which study results can be *applied outside the laboratory* to real-life situations. Experiments where all of the variables are tightly controlled may have a high degree of reliability and internal validity but not be very generalizable to the real world.

(Choice D) Neutrality refers to the extent to which an experiment is objective, unbiased, and detached from the researcher's expectations. Neutrality implies that the results are legitimate and trustworthy. Complete neutrality is impossible, but steps are often taken to make research as neutral as possible. For example, a double-blind procedure means that neither the subjects nor the researcher knows who is receiving the treatment tested.

Educational objective:

Reliability describes the degree to which a measure is consistent (eg, a similar score for a person who takes the same assessment twice). Reliability also describes the extent to which an experiment is replicable or reproducible (ie, repeating the experiment produces similar results).

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To prevent groupthink in Groups 2, 3, and 4, experimenters could:

- ✓ ☒ A. require each group member to defend an alternative estimate during discussion. [92%]
- ☐ B. reward groups that reach a consensus quickly. [2%]
- ☐ C. have groups participate in 15 minutes of team-building activities before discussion. [3%]
- ☐ D. ask the groups to agree on a team leader. [1%]

Correct

92% answered correctly

Explanation:

Causes & characteristics of groupthink	
Causes	Group characteristics
• Biased leadership • High group cohesiveness • Homogeneity of group members • Stressful decision, external threats • Insulation from alternative viewpoints	• Closed-mindedness • Opposition demonized • Members pressured to conform • Dissent self-censored, suppressed • Overestimation of group power, group morality

Groupthink occurs when a group arrives at an **incorrect** or **irrational decision** because group members, in an effort to get along and reach consensus, **do not critically evaluate** all available information. Groupthink is characterized by group harmony and enthusiasm at the expense of rational decision-making. Groupthink often occurs because members do not want to cause discord or thwart progress toward a consensus.

Groupthink tends to occur in groups that are highly cohesive and homogenous (group members are very similar), fail to consider

alternatives, attempt to make a decision under stressful circumstances, and/or have leaders who are well liked and strongly favor one position. Groups demonstrating groupthink tend to be overly confident in their position or stance and disparaging of opponents and dissenting opinions.

Requiring each group member to defend one alternative estimate during discussion would be the best way for experimenters to prevent groupthink because it would compel each group member to participate during discussion (instead of passively agreeing with others) and force the group to listen to alternatives.

(Choice B) Rewarding groups that reach a consensus quickly is more likely to *cause* groupthink than prevent it because the promise of a reward is likely to lead members to suppress their own opinions in favor of going along with the group decision.

(Choice C) Team-building activities are more likely to *cause* groupthink than prevent it because groups that are more cohesive are more likely to sacrifice rational decision-making for group harmony.

(Choice D) Requiring group members to agree on a team leader is more likely to *cause* groupthink than prevent it, because an agreed-upon leader is more likely to encourage the other group members to go with the consensus decision.

Educational objective:

Groupthink is a phenomenon whereby group members arrive at incorrect or irrational decisions because harmony and consensus are valued above critical analysis of the information. Groupthink is more likely to occur in groups that are cohesive, homogenous, and insulated from outside opinions; have biased leadership; and are experiencing stress.

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Behavioral Sciences

QID:400567

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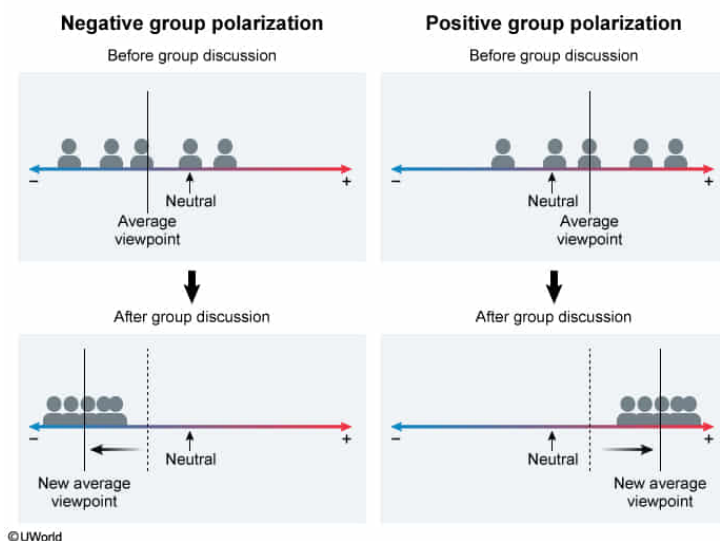
What does the Group 5 estimate most demonstrate?

- ☐ A. Regression to the mean [7%]
- ☐ B. Social facilitation effect [6%]
- ☐ C. Social desirability bias [4%]
- ✓ ☒ D. Group polarization [81%]

Correct

81% answered correctly

Explanation:



Group polarization occurs when the average attitude or proposed course of action of a group becomes **more extreme after group discussion**. For example, if the average favorability rating for a political candidate among group members becomes even more extreme after group discussion, group polarization has occurred.

Group opinions or attitudes can polarize in either direction (ie, become relatively more positive or more negative compared to original average). Group polarization is more likely to occur when the group is composed of members who share a similar opinion to begin with.

The members of Group 5 were the four members originally in Group 1 who arrived at the lowest independent risk estimates (no higher than

20%). As part of Group 5, they collectively arrived at an *even lower* risk estimate of 10% after group discussion, reflecting group polarization.

(Choice A) Regression to the mean refers to the tendency of extreme data points in a distribution to regress toward the mean value of the distribution upon repeated measurements. For example, an athlete who has an outstanding performance in one game is likely to underperform in the next game. This effect would predict that the Group 5 estimate would be *less*, not more, extreme.

(Choice B) The social facilitation effect refers to the enhancement of performance when an individual has an audience (eg, people tie their shoes faster when being watched), but it predicts that only simple or well-learned tasks improve. This effect does not explain why the Group 5 estimate was even lower.

(Choice C) Social desirability bias describes the tendency of research subjects to respond to experimental questions in a way that makes them look better in the eyes of the experimenter, such as overestimating positive behaviors (eg, exercising) and underestimating negative behaviors (eg, drinking alcohol). This bias is unrelated to group members coming to a consensus estimate for cancer risk.

Educational objective:

Group polarization occurs when the average attitudes/opinions of group members become more extreme after group discussion. Group polarization is more likely to occur in groups composed of like-minded members. Opinions can be polarized toward either extreme.

Time spent: 0 sec
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Behavioral Sciences

QID: 400568
System:
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Social loafing would be best demonstrated by members of:

- ☐ A. Group 1 arriving at their individual estimates after careful consideration. [1%]
- ☐ B. Group 2 spending the most time discussing compared to Groups 3 and 4. [22%]
- ✔ ☒ C. Group 3 arriving at a consensus in the shortest amount of time compared to Groups 2 and 4. [47%]
- ☐ D. Group 5 spending less time discussing compared to Groups 2, 3, and 4. [28%]

Correct

47% answered correctly

Explanation:

Causes of social loafing	
Diffusion of responsibility	As group size increases, individuals feel less responsible for the success of the group.
Lack of motivation	Individuals perceive their efforts as less influential on the overall group performance.
Avoidance of over-effort	No one wants to be the hardest working member of the group without being rewarded accordingly.
Lack of oversight	Without an arbiter recording each person's effort, individuals feel able to get by with minimal effort.
Noncohesive group	When group members lack a sense of cohesion, social loafing is more likely to occur.

Social loafing occurs when an individual **exerts less effort** as a member of a group than when alone. For example, studies show that people tend to applaud more loudly when alone than when part of an audience.

Several factors contribute to social loafing. As group size increases, members begin to feel less accountable for the overall performance of the group. Social loafing is also "contagious": When group members realize that others are slacking in their efforts, they are more likely to begin slacking as well. Furthermore, when the performance of a group is not monitored, people are less likely to put forth their best effort. In addition, when group members lack a sense of unity or cohesiveness, they are likely to put forth minimal effort.

Members of Group 3 arriving at a decision in the shortest amount of time suggests that members were not fully participating in the group process, which is indicative of social loafing. Spending little time debating suggests that group members were exerting minimal effort and passively accepting the group decision.

(Choices A and B) Careful consideration (Group 1) and spending a lot of time debating (Group 2) both suggest social loafing was not occurring.

(Choice D) Group 5 members spending less time debating than Groups 2, 3, and 4 could be attributed to the fact that there were fewer members and they all started off with very similar estimates, so less discussion was needed.

Educational objective:

Social loafing occurs when an individual expends less effort at a task when part of a group than when performing alone. Increased group size, lack of motivation, absence of leadership or oversight, and disconnectedness all contribute to social loafing.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400569

System:
Identity and Social Interaction